

FIRESTARTER

YOUNG POETS PRIZE 2026

MY VOICE, MY FUTURE
THE SPARK PACK

Dear Firestarter, start something.

Burn by all means divinely given.

Start a revolution. Be one.

Let the earth feel your heat.

We do not eat cold or lukewarm.

You are not a bundle of excuses.

You are not a cliché.

You are the standard.

Stand and be seen. Now.

Shola Amaraibi

Welcome, Firestarter

This pack is yours. It has everything you need to enter the Firestarter Young Poets Prize 2026: the theme, what to write, how long it should be, and exactly how to send it in.

You do not have to be "good at poetry" already. You just have to be honest. This year's theme is My Voice, My Future, and the only person who can write that poem is you.

Read this pack with a parent, guardian, or teacher if that helps. Then start writing.

The Theme: My Voice, My Future

Your voice is the way you see the world that no one else sees in exactly the same way. Your future is what you are walking toward. The person you are becoming, the thing you want to build, change, or say before anyone tells you it is impossible.

This poem is your chance to say something true about your own voice and your own future, in your own words, your own rhythm, your own style. It can be hopeful, angry, funny, quiet, or loud. It just has to be yours.

Who Can Enter

- Junior Poets, ages 10 to 13
- Senior Poets, ages 14 to 17
- Any secondary school student in Lagos State
- Entry is free

What Makes a Strong Entry

Every entry, Junior and Senior, is read for the same five things. Think of them as five questions your poem should be able to answer:

VOICE

Does this sound like you, and no one else? Not a poem you think a judge wants. The one only you could have written.

THOUGHT

Is there a real idea here? Something you noticed, questioned, or figured out, not just a nice-sounding line.

CRAFT

Have you shaped your words on purpose: the images, the rhythm, the way lines break? Craft is what separates a poem from a paragraph.

PRESENCE

This one matters later, not now. If you are shortlisted, you will be asked to perform your poem on video. Presence is how you carry your words out loud.

TOOLS

Technology can help you think. It should never think for you. Your Reflection (see below) is where you show the poem is genuinely yours.

How to Write in Your Own Voice

Most people freeze because they think a poem has to sound a certain way: fancy, serious, full of words they do not normally use. Do not do that. Here is how to start:

- Start with something true, not something impressive. "I'm scared of failing my exams" beats a big word you don't fully understand.
- Say it the way you would say it out loud to someone you trust. Then shape it.
- Use a real memory, a real place, a real person, even if you change the details after.
- Read it back out loud. If it does not sound like you talking, rewrite the line, not the idea.
- You do not need rhyme. Free verse, which is poetry without a rhyme pattern, is completely welcome and often stronger.

Prompts, If You Need a Way In

You do not have to use these. If your own idea is already forming, follow that instead.

- Write about a version of your future nobody has given you permission to want yet.
- Write to your 25-year-old self. What do you want them to remember about being you right now?
- Write about a moment you were told to be quiet, and what you would say now.
- Write about something you have never said out loud to your family.
- Write about what "voice" means when you feel unheard.

Using AI: What Is Allowed

AI tools (like ChatGPT, Claude, or similar) can be useful for thinking, but they cannot write your poem for you.

- Not allowed: asking an AI tool to write, finish, or substantially rewrite your poem.
- Allowed: using AI to look up a word, understand a poetic form, or check your spelling, the same way a dictionary would help you.
- Every entry is reviewed for originality, and your Reflection helps us understand where each poem came from. A poem that is copied, or not genuinely the student's own work, will be disqualified.

If you are not sure whether something counts, ask yourself: did I do the thinking, or did I let something else do it for me? If it is the second one, do not submit it that way.

What to Submit

Every student submits the same two things. There is no video at this stage. That only comes later, and only for students who are shortlisted.

1. Your Poem

- Junior Poets (10 to 13): 10 to 20 lines, roughly 125 to 250 words.
- Senior Poets (14 to 17): 25 to 40 lines, roughly 300 to 500 words.
- One original poem. Include a title.

The upper number is a ceiling, not a target. Write what the poem needs, no more and no less.

2. Your Reflection

A short piece of writing, not a recording, of 3 to 5 sentences (roughly 60 to 100 words). In your own words, tell us:

- What gave you the idea for this poem?
- What were you trying to say, or figure out, by writing it?

This is written, just like your poem. You are not being asked to record anything at this stage.

How to Submit

Fill in the official entry form. It takes about ten minutes. You will need:

- Your poem title
- Your full poem, typed or pasted in
- Your Reflection
- Basic details: your name, age category, school, and a parent or guardian contact

You do not need a Google account to submit. Please enter only one poem per student.

If You Need Another Way to Enter

If a student cannot use the online form, for any reason, including disability or lack of a device, contact the Firestarter team and we will find another way for that student to take part. No student should be left out because of how the form works.

Deadline

Wednesday, 30 September 2026, 11:59 PM (WAT). Entries close at the deadline. Build in time before then. Do not wait for the last hour.

What Happens After You Submit

- October: every entry is read and scored on the poem and the Reflection alone. No video yet.
- 1 November: the shortlist is announced. Shortlisted students are invited to send a short video of themselves performing their own poem.
- Early to mid November: the video round. This is where Presence is scored, and the top 100 finalists are chosen.
- Late November: the 100 finalists attend the Firestarter Creative-Tech Lab, a hands-on session with the Firestarter team.
- 19 and 20 December: winners are announced at Firestarter: The Musical, MUSON Centre, Lagos.

Only students on the shortlist will be asked for a video. If you are not shortlisted, that does not happen, so do not worry about filming anything until you hear from us.

What You Could Win

- Top 100 finalists: certificates, recognition, a place at the Creative-Tech Lab, and a spot at the December grand final.
- Top 3 students: education-support awards worth ₦1,000,000 in total, paid toward school fees or approved learning needs.

This Prize is built around growth, not just prizes. The goal is to open doors for young voices, not only to reward one winning poem.

A Note for Parents and Guardians

Thank you for supporting your child through this. A few things worth knowing:

- This is a genuine skills programme, not just a competition. It builds voice, original thought, creative confidence, and the judgement to use technology without being led by it. These are skills your child will need well beyond this Prize.
- Entry is free, and no purchase or payment is ever required at any stage. If anyone asks a family for money to enter or advance, that is not part of this programme. Please contact us directly.
- Your child's poem and Reflection will be read by Firestarter judges for scoring purposes. No child's name, video, photo, or written work will be shared publicly without your explicit, separate consent.
- If your child is shortlisted and a video is requested, that video will only be used for judging unless you separately agree to further use. We will always ask first.
- You are welcome to help your child understand this pack and the form, but the poem and Reflection must be genuinely your child's own work.

If you have questions at any point, reach out to the Firestarter team. Contact details are on the official entry page.

Consent, Privacy and Safeguarding

Because this programme works directly with children, we hold ourselves to a clear standard:

- Parental or guardian consent is required for every entry before a student's work is judged.
- No child's name, image, video, or written work is published, posted, or shared outside the judging process without separate, explicit parental consent.
- Personal information collected through the entry form is used only to run the Prize, meaning to contact students and families and to verify eligibility. It is not shared beyond the Firestarter team and its judging panel.
- Any video submitted at the shortlist stage is used only for judging purposes unless further, specific permission is given.
- Any concern about a child's safety or wellbeing connected to this programme should be raised immediately with the Firestarter team.

Now go write something only you could have written.

The Firestarter Collective Africa | firestartermethod.com